

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cross-Cultural Leadership English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For managers, cross-border teams, HR partners, and meeting facilitators.

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Check meaning before assuming agreement

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Challenge ideas respectfully

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

03 Make authority and participation clear

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

04 Negotiate realistic commitments

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

05 Include every voice in a meeting

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

06 Give specific, useful feedback

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

07 Coordinate across offices

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Check meaning before assuming agreement

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

assumption - Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

clarification - A question or explanation that makes meaning more precise.

expectation - A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Reopening the launch agreement

The branch manager follows up on the lesson's launch meeting after receiving a staffing concern.

01 • Branch manager: I recorded agreement when you said the plan was fine. Your email suggests a staffing concern.

02 • Operations lead: I meant the launch sequence looked reasonable, not that we had enough people.

03 • Branch manager: Thank you for the clarification. Which part of my recorded expectation needs correcting?

04 • Operations lead: Please separate support for the sequence from confirmation that staffing is sufficient.

05 • Branch manager: Was your staffing concern already resolved when we finished the meeting?

06 • Operations lead: No. My email raises it because we still need to discuss coverage.

07 • Branch manager: Then my assumption was too broad. I should not have recorded full agreement.

08 • Operations lead: Could we reopen that point before presenting the plan as settled?

09 • Branch manager: Yes. I'll correct the record and invite both colleagues to clarify their positions.

10 • Operations lead: That works. We can discuss coverage without implying that either colleague approved it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Available does not mean assigned

A separate fictional branch case: a training coordinator has two free hours Thursday, but no assignment has been agreed.

01 • Branch manager: You said you were available Thursday. May I announce you as the workshop facilitator?

02 • Training coordinator: Could you clarify the assignment first? I have two hours free, not an unlimited opening.

03 • Branch manager: I was assuming availability meant a commitment to lead the whole session.

04 • Training coordinator: That wasn't my intention. I need the session length and preparation expectation.

05 • Branch manager: We haven't settled either detail. What can I accurately tell the planning group?

06 • Training coordinator: Say that I have a possible two-hour slot, subject to reviewing the work.

07 • Branch manager: So you haven't accepted facilitation or preparation duties at this stage?

08 • Training coordinator: Correct. Please ask the group to define those duties before requesting confirmation.

09 • Branch manager: I'll bring back a specific request instead of adding your name to the agenda.

10 • Training coordinator: Thanks. Once the scope is clear, I can give you a definite answer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Whose end of day?

A separate fictional handoff connects offices using Eastern and Pacific time. A request says only 'end of day.'

01 • Branch coordinator: Your request says end of day. Which time zone should we use for this handoff?

02 • Headquarters analyst: I meant Eastern time, but I didn't include a specific hour.

03 • Branch coordinator: Our team uses Pacific time. That leaves room for a different assumption.

04 • Headquarters analyst: You're right. I also need to clarify whether I want preliminary or reviewed numbers.

05 • Branch coordinator: Which version does your next meeting actually require us to supply?

06 • Headquarters analyst: I need reviewed numbers, but I haven't checked when your review finishes.

07 • Branch coordinator: Then let's establish availability before turning that expectation into a deadline.

08 • Headquarters analyst: Could you check the review schedule while I confirm the meeting's cutoff?

09 • Branch coordinator: Yes. We'll agree an exact time and zone after those two checks.

10 • Headquarters analyst: I'll leave the delivery time unconfirmed until we have that clarification.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Check meaning before assuming agreement

In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

Scenario 2 | A calendar acceptance with a condition

In a fictional branch, an analyst accepted a meeting invitation but added a note that they could attend only the first fifteen minutes. The manager has scheduled that analyst's item last in a thirty-minute meeting.

Role A: You are the analyst. Clarify what your acceptance meant and request a workable speaking slot.

Role B: You are the manager. Check the time limit and discuss moving the item without assuming the agenda change is already agreed.

Possible opening: I accepted the invitation for the first fifteen minutes, but my item is currently last.

Success checks

- Distinguish accepting an invitation from full-meeting availability.
- State the fifteen-minute limit accurately.
- Agree a feasible speaking slot or an explicit follow-up.

Add a complication: Another participant needs the first ten minutes for a separate decision; negotiate the remaining time.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Challenge ideas respectfully

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward.

SITUATION

A colleague says, "This proposal makes no sense." The group goes quiet. You want to hear the concern without accepting personal attacks.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

objection - A stated concern or reason for not accepting a proposal.

behavioral example - A specific description of what a person did or said.

boundary - A limit on acceptable conduct, responsibility, access, or scope.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal without pretending agreement. Name the specific problem and its implication, then ask a focused question or propose a next step. Be direct when a safety or ethical boundary requires it.

I understand the goal. My concern is

That statement goes beyond

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Compare this wording: That idea is ridiculous.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Disagree with a useful reason

4. Check the language

1. Which response identifies a specific assumption and evidence against it?
 - A. The proposal appears optimistic, and I would prefer a slower approach.
 - B. I would like another discussion before we proceed with the proposal.
 - C. The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open.
2. Which follow-up makes disagreement actionable?
 - A. Could we ask for general feedback before sending the next update?
 - B. Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan?
 - C. Could we confirm the plan and discuss the missing approval later?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Turning a dismissal into an objection

A separate fictional branch proposal allocates one employee to two simultaneous reception desks. The facilitator addresses a department lead's broad dismissal of that proposal.

01 • Meeting facilitator: You said this proposal makes no sense. Which specific assumption are you objecting to?

02 • Department lead: It assigns one employee to two reception desks operating at the same time.

03 • Meeting facilitator: That's a concrete concern. Please explain the coverage problem without dismissing the people who drafted it.

04 • Department lead: One person cannot cover both desks simultaneously. Are you asking me to soften that objection?

05 • Meeting facilitator: No. Keep the objection direct; the boundary concerns personal criticism, not disagreement about staffing.

06 • Department lead: Then we need either another employee or different operating times for the desks.

07 • Meeting facilitator: Additional staffing isn't confirmed. Could we assess staggered hours before assuming that resource is available?

08 • Department lead: Yes, but we'd need to check whether staggered hours meet the reception requirements.

09 • Meeting facilitator: I'll ask the proposal owner to assess those options with the requirement still visible.

10 • Department lead: Please record simultaneous coverage as unresolved, not as an approved staffing arrangement.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Protecting a review step

A separate fictional branch plans a customer mailing. The proposed schedule omits a review step agreed by this project team.

01 • Campaign lead: Let's remove the review meeting so the mailing can go out sooner.

02 • Branch manager: I understand the timing goal. My objection is that our agreed review would disappear.

03 • Campaign lead: Do you think the team is incapable of producing a reliable mailing?

04 • Branch manager: I'm not questioning anyone's ability. I'm pointing to a specific missing step.

05 • Campaign lead: Could we review only the changed sections instead of meeting about every page?

06 • Branch manager: That may work, provided the reviewer agrees the narrower scope covers the changes.

07 • Campaign lead: So your boundary concerns releasing unreviewed changes, not keeping a meeting for its own sake?

08 • Branch manager: Yes. Let's ask the reviewer what they need before confirming a shorter process.

09 • Campaign lead: I'll bring the changed sections and request a focused review proposal.

10 • Branch manager: Then we can discuss the date with that condition visible, rather than assume approval.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Responding to an interruption complaint

A separate fictional branch plan schedules training Monday, but its required practice accounts will be available Wednesday. The project lead interrupted the scheduler twice while this dependency was being explained.

01 • Scheduler: You interrupted me twice while I explained the dependency. Could I finish the timing concern?

02 • Project lead: Yes. I thought the dates were settled, but please explain what the proposal overlooks.

03 • Scheduler: Training is Monday, while the required practice accounts won't be available until Wednesday.

04 • Project lead: Could the trainer demonstrate the process Monday and let participants practice afterward?

05 • Scheduler: That changes the session scope. The planned Monday session requires participants to use those accounts.

06 • Project lead: Then my proposal assumes access before it's available. We should assess moving the session.

07 • Scheduler: Yes. Please let me complete these explanations before answering; otherwise the dependency gets lost.

08 • Project lead: That's a fair boundary. Could you check a later session with the trainer?

09 • Scheduler: I'll ask, but I can't confirm their availability or a revised date yet.

10 • Project lead: Understood. We'll record the Monday conflict and keep the replacement date pending that check.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Challenge ideas respectfully

A colleague says, "This proposal makes no sense." The group goes quiet. You want to hear the concern without accepting personal attacks.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want to move quickly and initially overlook a relevant condition. Ask why it matters, then consider a practical route forward that respects the real constraint.

Second round: The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

Model for scenario 1: I'd like to understand the objection. Which assumption do you disagree with? Please focus on the proposal so we can examine it together.

Scenario 2 | A scorecard is called pointless

A fictional branch uses a proposed weekly scorecard with six measures. A supervisor calls it pointless because two measures duplicate an existing report. No one has assessed the other four.

Role A: You facilitate the discussion. Ask for a specific objection and prevent a blanket dismissal.

Role B: You are the supervisor. Explain the duplication and propose reviewing the remaining four measures.

Possible opening: Could we separate the two duplicated measures from the four we haven't assessed?

Success checks

- Focus on the two observed duplications.
- Respectfully separate work criticism from a personal judgment.
- Agree how to assess the remaining measures without assuming their value.

Add a complication: The sponsor interprets criticism of the scorecard as criticism of its author.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Make authority and participation clear

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

Your team wants more direction, but the manager has been answering every question. A new hire has stopped offering ideas.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

decision rights - The allocation of authority to recommend, approve, or make particular decisions.

role clarity - A shared understanding of a person's responsibilities and authority.

facilitation - Guiding a discussion so people can contribute, understand differences, and reach useful next steps.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. We can record their agreement without asking them.
 - B. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
 - C. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.
 - B. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.
 - C. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Direction without answering every question

The manager in the lesson invites the new hire to discuss participation before the next team meeting.

01 • Branch manager: I've been answering every question, and you haven't offered ideas recently. I'd like your perspective.

02 • Operations associate: I'm unsure whether you want suggestions or only questions about decisions already made.

03 • Branch manager: That shows a role clarity problem. I haven't distinguished discussion from direction.

04 • Operations associate: Could you tell us which items are open before asking for contributions?

05 • Branch manager: Yes. I can identify open questions and explain whose decision rights apply.

06 • Operations associate: Would I be expected to defend an idea immediately in front of everyone?

07 • Branch manager: We can allow questions first. I don't want to treat an early suggestion as a commitment.

08 • Operations associate: Then I can contribute without pretending I have a fully developed proposal.

09 • Branch manager: I'll change the facilitation and invite other views before offering my own answer.

10 • Operations associate: Let's try that next meeting and check whether the invitation is clear.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A recommendation is not purchasing approval

A separate fictional branch: a facilities group may recommend furniture, while the branch director holds purchase approval.

01 • Facilities coordinator: The group preferred the adjustable desks. Can I tell the supplier to proceed?

02 • Branch director: Not yet. Your group has recommendation responsibility; I hold purchase approval in this project.

03 • Facilities coordinator: I thought unanimous support gave us decision rights over the order as well.

04 • Branch director: I should have made that distinction earlier. What concerns came up during the discussion?

05 • Facilities coordinator: We haven't heard from the reception team, which will also use the desks.

06 • Branch director: Then invite their perspective before treating the recommendation as complete.

07 • Facilities coordinator: Should I reopen every preference, or focus on their actual work requirements?

08 • Branch director: Focus on requirements and any unresolved concerns. We don't need another popularity vote.

09 • Facilities coordinator: I'll gather that input and bring a recommendation with the open questions identified.

10 • Branch director: Good. The supplier should receive no purchase instruction until I review it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Who owns the shift decision?

A separate fictional branch: two supervisors each believe the other approves a proposed shift swap; no authority has been confirmed.

01 • Shift supervisor: The team discussed the swap, but I thought your office would approve it.

02 • Operations supervisor: I expected you to decide. We clearly need role clarity before giving an answer.

03 • Shift supervisor: Could we ask the operations manager to confirm the decision rights for this case?

04 • Operations supervisor: Yes. Meanwhile, have both affected shifts had a chance to explain their concerns?

05 • Shift supervisor: The morning team spoke, but the evening representative hasn't joined the discussion yet.

06 • Operations supervisor: Let's invite that perspective without implying that consultation itself authorizes the swap.

07 • Shift supervisor: What should I tell the staff members waiting for a response today?

08 • Operations supervisor: Say the request is under discussion and approval responsibility is still being clarified.

09 • Shift supervisor: I'll arrange the missing conversation and ask the manager who can decide.

10 • Operations supervisor: I'll keep the current arrangement unchanged until an authorized decision is communicated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Make authority and participation clear

Your team wants more direction, but the manager has been answering every question. A new hire has stopped offering ideas.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: I'll make the final decision on staffing. Before that, I want each of you to suggest one option. You can speak now or send a note after the meeting.

Scenario 2 | The acting chair's limits

In a fictional branch, a coordinator is chairing a meeting while the director is absent. The group can recommend a new visitor process, but only the director can approve it. Reception has not spoken.

Role A: You are the acting chair. Invite reception's input and close with a recommendation, not an approval.

Role B: You represent reception. Ask how visitor delays will be considered and who makes the final decision.

Possible opening: Before we make a recommendation, I'd like reception's view on the proposed visitor process.

Success checks

- Invite the missing operational perspective.
- Identify the director's approval role.
- Close with a recommendation and any unresolved question clearly separated.

Add a complication: A participant asks you to announce immediate implementation because everyone present seems satisfied.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Negotiate realistic commitments

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

Headquarters asks for a report on Friday. The local team can produce verified figures on Monday or a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

commitment - An explicit promise or accepted responsibility to do something.

tradeoff - A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

deadline - The latest agreed or required time for completing an action.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Friday estimate or Monday verification

Headquarters and the branch negotiate the two reporting options supplied in the lesson.

01 • Headquarters analyst: We requested the report for Friday. Can your branch make that commitment?

02 • Branch reporting lead: We can provide a clearly labeled estimate Friday or verified figures Monday.

03 • Headquarters analyst: The review meeting is waiting on information. Could Friday's estimate be presented as final?

04 • Branch reporting lead: No. That would hide the tradeoff between the deadline and the verification status.

05 • Headquarters analyst: What would we be able to say accurately about the Friday version?

06 • Branch reporting lead: That it is an estimate and that verified figures are available Monday.

07 • Headquarters analyst: Could we use the estimate for discussion, then replace it with the verified report?

08 • Branch reporting lead: Yes, provided the provisional status stays visible wherever the estimate is shared.

09 • Headquarters analyst: I'll take that condition to the meeting owner before confirming their preferred option.

10 • Branch reporting lead: Then let me know the choice. I won't describe Friday's figures as verified.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A smaller orientation session

A separate fictional branch has one trainer available for a two-hour session; the requested full orientation takes four hours.

01 • Hiring manager: Can you fit the complete orientation into the two hours the trainer has?

02 • Training lead: The current program takes four hours. Compressing it would change what participants receive.

03 • Hiring manager: What practical option can you offer without promising another trainer we don't have?

04 • Training lead: We could propose a two-hour introduction and arrange the remaining content separately.

05 • Hiring manager: Would that mean new hires had completed the full orientation on day one?

06 • Training lead: No. We would need to identify the unfinished sections and agree their timing.

07 • Hiring manager: I can accept a staged approach, but I need the remaining session date reviewed.

08 • Training lead: I'll check availability before making that commitment. The second date isn't confirmed.

09 • Hiring manager: Please describe the scope tradeoff clearly when you bring the proposal back.

10 • Training lead: I will. For now, we have a possible introduction, not a shortened full program.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The visit agenda exceeds the available hour

A separate fictional branch visit has a confirmed one-hour discussion slot and six requested topics, each allocated fifteen minutes.

01 • Branch host: Six fifteen-minute topics need ninety minutes, but the visit includes only one hour.

02 • Regional director: Can we keep all six and simply speak faster to meet the deadline?

03 • Branch host: That risks losing the discussion. We could select four topics or seek a longer slot.

04 • Regional director: The visit schedule is fixed. Could the remaining two become a follow-up conversation?

05 • Branch host: Yes, if their owners agree. I can't commit their calendars on their behalf.

06 • Regional director: Then let me prioritize four topics, and you can ask about the follow-up.

07 • Branch host: Should we mark the other two as deferred rather than silently remove them?

08 • Regional director: Definitely. I want a clear tradeoff, not the impression that every issue was covered.

09 • Branch host: I'll circulate the revised scope and keep the follow-up timing unconfirmed.

10 • Regional director: Good. Our commitment is four topics in one hour, with two still to schedule.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Negotiate realistic commitments

Headquarters asks for a report on Friday. The local team can produce verified figures on Monday or a clearly labeled estimate on Friday.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: We can send an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday. Which would meet your need? If we send the estimate, I'll label the figures as provisional.

Scenario 2 | Coverage for a demonstration

A fictional branch can spare one specialist for either a thirty-minute customer demonstration or a thirty-minute internal rehearsal this afternoon, not both. A second specialist's availability is unknown.

Role A: You coordinate staffing. Offer the two feasible choices without promising extra coverage.

Role B: You organize the demonstration. Choose a priority and state what would need separate approval or scheduling.

Possible opening: We have one thirty-minute specialist slot, so we need to choose its purpose.

Success checks

- State the capacity limit and both options.
- Keep the second specialist's availability unknown.
- Agree one commitment and identify the deferred activity.

Add a complication: The organizer asks you to promise the second specialist before their availability is checked.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Include every voice in a meeting

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

Three people speak at once during a hybrid meeting. A remote colleague's question is missed, and nobody knows who can approve the plan.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

facilitation - Guiding a discussion so people can contribute, understand differences, and reach useful next steps.

meeting minutes - A written record of key discussion points, decisions, and agreed actions.

action item - A specific task agreed during a discussion, usually assigned to a person.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - B. We can record their agreement without asking them.
 - C. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - B. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.
 - C. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Recovering the remote question

The lesson's hybrid meeting has overlapping speakers, a missed remote question, and unclear approval responsibility.

01 • Meeting chair: Let's pause the overlapping discussion. Our remote colleague had a question we didn't hear.

02 • Remote project lead: Thank you. Before discussing implementation, I need to know who can approve this plan.

03 • Meeting chair: That hasn't been established. I won't record approval in the meeting minutes.

04 • Remote project lead: Could someone take an action item to confirm the decision owner?

05 • Meeting chair: I'll take that action. Is there another concern we missed while people were speaking?

06 • Remote project lead: I'd like each speaker to finish before the next person responds.

07 • Meeting chair: Agreed. I'll call on people in turn and check the remote participants before closing.

08 • Remote project lead: Does that mean today's discussion can still produce recommendations without a final decision?

09 • Meeting chair: Yes. We'll distinguish recommendations, unresolved questions, and the pending approval route.

10 • Remote project lead: Then please read that distinction back at the end so everyone can confirm it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A chat comment omitted from the summary

A separate fictional meeting: a warehouse representative posted a delivery-access concern in chat, but the chair's summary omitted it.

01 • Warehouse representative: My delivery-access concern was in the chat, but it isn't in your summary.

02 • Meeting chair: Thank you for catching that. Could you explain it aloud before we close?

03 • Warehouse representative: I want the team to check delivery access before recommending the new reception layout.

04 • Meeting chair: So the concern is an unresolved access check, not a rejection of the entire layout?

05 • Warehouse representative: Exactly. Please don't record me as either fully supportive or opposed.

06 • Meeting chair: I'll add the concern to the meeting minutes and ask who can investigate.

07 • Warehouse representative: I can describe the delivery workflow, but facilities needs to assess the layout.

08 • Meeting chair: Then your action item is to explain the workflow, not certify the layout.

09 • Warehouse representative: That is accurate. Could we invite facilities before choosing an implementation date?

10 • Meeting chair: Yes. I'll request their input and leave the recommendation conditional on that discussion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The timer and the unanswered question

A separate fictional planning call has three minutes remaining; a service coordinator has been waiting to ask about staffing.

01 • Service coordinator: We have three minutes left, and I still haven't asked my staffing question.

02 • Meeting facilitator: Let's protect a minute for it. We should not close by assuming silence means agreement.

03 • Service coordinator: Who will assess coverage before this plan is recommended to the branch director?

04 • Meeting facilitator: We haven't assigned that action item. Are you able to describe the coverage requirements?

05 • Service coordinator: Yes, but I can't confirm the staffing allocation without the scheduling lead.

06 • Meeting facilitator: Then I'll invite that lead to a follow-up rather than name you as approver.

07 • Service coordinator: Please make that distinction in the meeting minutes; it affects what others expect.

08 • Meeting facilitator: I'll record your input task and the unresolved allocation question separately.

09 • Service coordinator: Can you read those two points now so I can check them?

10 • Meeting facilitator: You describe coverage needs; the scheduling lead's input and the director's decision remain pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Include every voice in a meeting

Three people speak at once during a hybrid meeting. A remote colleague's question is missed, and nobody knows who can approve the plan.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Let's hear Morgan's question first. Then we'll take one comment at a time. Before we finish, can we confirm who approves the plan and when?

Scenario 2 | Rejoining after a lost connection

A fictional procurement meeting discussed two suppliers while the technical lead lost connection. No supplier was approved, but the returning lead heard only 'we are moving forward.'

Role A: You chair the meeting. Restore the missing context and invite the technical concern before closing.

Role B: You are the technical lead. Ask what was discussed, what was decided, and how your compatibility concern will be handled.

Possible opening: Before we close, let me separate the supplier discussion from any approval you may have missed.

Success checks

- State that neither supplier was approved.
- Give the returning participant a protected speaking turn.
- Agree an owner for the compatibility question and an accurate closing summary.

Add a complication: Only two minutes remain, and another participant wants to end without hearing the concern.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Give specific, useful feedback

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

SITUATION

Two weekly reports arrived a day after the agreed deadline. The manager does not know the reason. Other teams depend on the figures.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

feedback - Information about performance intended to support understanding and improvement.

expectation - A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

support plan - Agreed actions and resources intended to help a person or team meet an identified need.

3. Notice the language

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Compare this wording: You are always careless.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give feedback people can use

4. Check the language

1. Which feedback begins with observable behavior?
 - A. I think the team needs to be more committed to the updates.
 - B. The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.
 - C. The last two updates seemed less professional than usual.
2. Which follow-up invites useful information before agreeing on support?
 - A. What is making this part of the task difficult?
 - B. Can you promise this will never happen again?
 - C. Would another reminder solve this problem?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two late reports without a guessed cause

The lesson's manager gives feedback on two reports that arrived one day late; the cause remains unknown.

01 • Branch manager: The last two weekly reports arrived one day after our agreed deadline.

02 • Reporting analyst: Are you saying that I haven't been taking the reporting work seriously?

03 • Branch manager: No. I'm describing the timing, not your attitude. Other teams depend on those figures.

04 • Reporting analyst: I appreciate that distinction. What would you like to establish in this conversation?

05 • Branch manager: First, what is making delivery difficult? I don't yet know the reason.

06 • Reporting analyst: I'd like to review the reporting steps before giving you an explanation I can't support.

07 • Branch manager: That's reasonable. Let's identify the obstacle before choosing a support plan.

08 • Reporting analyst: Could we also confirm the expectation for flagging a likely delay?

09 • Branch manager: Yes. We'll agree when to raise that warning and review how the next report goes.

10 • Reporting analyst: Then we have a concrete improvement to discuss without assuming the cause today.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An update without a next action

A separate fictional branch: two project updates listed problems but omitted the requested next-action section.

01 • Project manager: Your last two updates listed the problems but left out the agreed next-action section.

02 • Project coordinator: I thought describing each problem would tell readers what needed to happen.

03 • Project manager: The effect was that readers couldn't tell who was being asked to act.

04 • Project coordinator: Could you give me feedback on the distinction rather than just the format?

05 • Project manager: Certainly. A problem describes the situation; an action request identifies what someone should do next.

06 • Project coordinator: So I shouldn't invent an owner when we haven't agreed one?

07 • Project manager: Correct. Say the owner is unresolved and request a decision about it.

08 • Project coordinator: I'll use that approach in the next update and keep unknown assignments visible.

09 • Project manager: Let's review one example together as a support plan before the next distribution.

10 • Project coordinator: That helps. I understand the expectation now: actionable information, not merely an extra heading.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Feedback on rushed explanations

A separate fictional onboarding session: a trainer changed screens twice before a new coordinator finished a question.

01 • Learning manager: During today's demonstration, you changed screens twice before the coordinator finished asking a question.

02 • Trainer: I was trying to complete the agenda. Did the coordinator say the explanation was unclear?

03 • Learning manager: I haven't asked them, so I can't claim that. My feedback concerns the observed interruptions.

04 • Trainer: What change would make the next demonstration more useful without abandoning the schedule?

05 • Learning manager: Could you pause for the question and state what you are about to show?

06 • Trainer: That may take longer. Can we review the number of examples in the session?

07 • Learning manager: Yes. Our support plan can include a smaller agenda with time for clarification.

08 • Trainer: I'd also like to ask the coordinator which step they wanted explained.

09 • Learning manager: Good. That invites their perspective instead of assuming the effect on their learning.

10 • Trainer: I'll do that and try the revised pacing at the next session.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Give specific, useful feedback

Two weekly reports arrived a day after the agreed deadline. The manager does not know the reason. Other teams depend on the figures.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: The last two reports arrived on Tuesday instead of Monday. That delayed our review. What is getting in the way, and what support would help you meet Monday's deadline?

Scenario 2 | Customer handoffs without contact names

In a fictional branch, the last two customer handoffs omitted a contact name. The receiving team had to ask who to call. The reason for the omissions is unknown.

Role A: You supervise the handoff process. Give specific feedback and ask about the obstacle.

Role B: You prepared the handoffs. Discuss how to flag an unknown contact rather than filling in a guess.

Possible opening: The last two handoffs had no contact name, so the receiving team had to ask who to call.

Success checks

- Describe the two omissions and their observed effect.
- Ask about the cause without assigning a personality label.
- Agree a support step and a way to identify genuinely unknown contacts.

Add a complication: The supervisor initially suggests another reminder before understanding the obstacle; revisit that assumption.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Coordinate across offices

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

Headquarters requests daily detail. The branch says the reporting takes an hour each day. Neither side has explained what information it actually needs.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

operating agreement - An agreed description of how people will coordinate work and responsibilities.

workload - The amount and type of work assigned or required over a period.

stakeholder engagement - The involvement and interaction of people affected by an activity or decision.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - B. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - C. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - B. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - C. How would you describe the next step in your own words?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Detail versus decision information

Headquarters and the branch discuss the lesson's daily report, which takes the branch an hour to prepare.

01 • Headquarters coordinator: We ask for daily detail, but I hear the report takes your branch an hour.

02 • Branch manager: Yes. Could we distinguish information you need to act from information that's merely available?

03 • Headquarters coordinator: That's useful. We haven't explained which decisions the daily detail supports.

04 • Branch manager: Without that explanation, we can't judge which parts of the workload add value.

05 • Headquarters coordinator: Would an operating agreement simply mean another reporting template for your team?

06 • Branch manager: Here, it would mean agreeing what we share, why, how often, and who responds.

07 • Headquarters coordinator: So the template would follow the information need, rather than define it?

08 • Branch manager: Exactly. Stakeholder engagement starts with asking users of the report what they actually require.

09 • Headquarters coordinator: I'll bring those decision needs to a discussion before requesting further detail.

10 • Branch manager: Then we can assess the workload and negotiate a reporting rhythm on that basis.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An exception report is not a complete log

A separate fictional branch proposes reporting delayed deliveries only; headquarters currently receives a log of every delivery.

01 • Branch analyst: Could we discuss an exception report instead of sending the full delivery log each day?

02 • Regional planner: Does exception report mean you would stop recording deliveries that arrive on time?

03 • Branch analyst: No. We would retain the complete log but highlight delays in the shared update.

04 • Regional planner: Then the distinction is between what you record and what you routinely send us?

05 • Branch analyst: Correct. The operating agreement would need to define which exceptions require attention.

06 • Regional planner: I sometimes need the full log for planning. Would that remain accessible?

07 • Branch analyst: That access needs agreement. I'm not proposing to remove it without discussing your needs.

08 • Regional planner: Let's identify when I need full detail and when a delay summary is sufficient.

09 • Branch analyst: We can then estimate the workload instead of assuming the shorter report saves time.

10 • Regional planner: Good. Bring both information needs into the proposal, including how I request the full log.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Consulted is not copied

A separate fictional branch project copies the service desk on announcements but has not asked about implementation workload.

01 • Project sponsor: The service desk receives every announcement, so stakeholder engagement is already covered.

02 • Branch operations lead: Receiving information isn't the same as being consulted about the work it creates.

03 • Project sponsor: What would consultation add beyond another copy of the project update?

04 • Branch operations lead: It would let the service desk explain its workload and flag unresolved support needs.

05 • Project sponsor: Would that give the desk authority to approve every project change?

06 • Branch operations lead: Not automatically. Input and decision rights are separate parts of an operating agreement.

07 • Project sponsor: So we should ask for their perspective without promising them approval authority?

08 • Branch operations lead: Yes, and explain how their input will be considered in the decision.

09 • Project sponsor: I'll invite a discussion about implementation work before calling the engagement complete.

10 • Branch operations lead: That will give us evidence about support needs instead of treating email distribution as participation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Coordinate across offices

Headquarters requests daily detail. The branch says the reporting takes an hour each day. Neither side has explained what information it actually needs.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Headquarters needs early notice of delays; the branch needs time to deliver the work. Could we try a short daily exception report and review the arrangement in two weeks?

Scenario 2 | Receipt versus resolution

In a fictional cross-office support arrangement, headquarters wants branches to acknowledge requests within one working day. A branch interprets that as a promise to resolve every request in one day. No resolution deadline has been agreed.

Role A: You coordinate headquarters support. Explain acknowledgment and resolution in plain English.

Role B: You manage a branch. Paraphrase the difference and ask how unresolved requests should be updated.

Possible opening: Acknowledging a request means confirming receipt; it does not mean the work is finished.

Success checks

- Preserve the one-working-day acknowledgment expectation.
- State that resolution timing remains unagreed.
- Propose discussing update expectations as part of the operating agreement.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to describe the arrangement as a one-day service guarantee.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

You interrupted a colleague twice while they explained a concern. They later say they felt dismissed. The concern is still unresolved.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

acknowledgment - Recognition of another person's contribution or confirmation that a message was received.

accountability - Responsibility for explaining decisions and following through on agreed work.

trust - Confidence that someone will act reliably and respectfully.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
 - B. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
 - C. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.
 - B. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.
 - C. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Returning to the concern you interrupted

The lesson's manager speaks with the colleague who felt dismissed after two interruptions.

01 • Branch manager: I interrupted you twice while you explained your concern. I'm sorry I cut you off.

02 • Project specialist: I felt dismissed, and the concern still hasn't been addressed by the team.

03 • Branch manager: I acknowledge that. My correction is to hear the full concern before responding.

04 • Project specialist: Are you inviting discussion now, or asking me to accept the original decision?

05 • Branch manager: I'm inviting discussion. I won't treat this apology as agreement on the unresolved issue.

06 • Project specialist: Then please let me finish, and check what you heard before proposing an answer.

07 • Branch manager: I will. I'll also make clear to the team that the concern remains open.

08 • Project specialist: That matters more to me than saying the misunderstanding has already been repaired.

09 • Branch manager: Understood. Accountability means changing the next interaction, not asking you to declare trust restored.

10 • Project specialist: Let's start with the concern, then agree what follow-up it actually needs.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Correcting an inaccurate endorsement

A separate fictional branch: a director told headquarters that a planner endorsed an option when the planner had only requested a cost review.

01 • Regional planner: Headquarters thinks I endorsed the option. I only asked for a cost review.

02 • Branch director: You're right. I described your position inaccurately, and I need to correct that message.

03 • Regional planner: Please don't call it a shared misunderstanding; my request did not express support.

04 • Branch director: I accept that accountability. I'll say I incorrectly turned a review request into an endorsement.

05 • Regional planner: Will the correction also explain that my position on the option remains undecided?

06 • Branch director: Yes. It will separate your request for evidence from any recommendation you might later make.

07 • Regional planner: I'd like to check the corrected description before it is sent.

08 • Branch director: Of course. That check won't require you to endorse the option or my original wording.

09 • Regional planner: Then we can return to the cost question without a false agreement hanging over it.

10 • Branch director: I'll correct the record first and keep the review request as the next action.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An apology without a cultural explanation

A separate fictional branch: a coordinator joked about a colleague's presentation style, and the colleague said the comment was unwelcome.

01 • Operations coordinator: My comment about your presentation style was unwelcome. I'm sorry I made it.

02 • Training specialist: Thank you. I don't want it explained away as a difference between offices or backgrounds.

03 • Operations coordinator: Agreed. I made the comment, and I can take responsibility without assigning cultural motives.

04 • Training specialist: What would useful feedback about the presentation look like instead?

05 • Operations coordinator: A specific example about the information or sequence, followed by a question about your intention.

06 • Training specialist: That would be different from making my personal style the subject of a joke.

07 • Operations coordinator: Yes. My acknowledgment doesn't require you to say the relationship is already repaired.

08 • Training specialist: I'd prefer that we focus on how we speak in the next review.

09 • Operations coordinator: I'll keep feedback specific and ask before offering comments beyond the work itself.

10 • Training specialist: Let's use that approach and allow trust to develop through what actually happens.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Repair misunderstandings and build trust

You interrupted a colleague twice while they explained a concern. They later say they felt dismissed. The concern is still unresolved.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: I interrupted you and missed part of your concern. I'm sorry. Could we return to it now? At our next meeting, I'll let you finish before I respond.

Scenario 2 | Leaving a contributor out of the credit

In a fictional branch, a manager's verbal project summary credited one analyst but omitted a coordinator who organized the interviews. The coordinator has raised the omission privately. The summary can be corrected at the next team meeting.

Role A: You are the manager. Acknowledge the omission and offer a precise correction without claiming intent you cannot establish.

Role B: You are the coordinator. Explain what contribution should be recognized and request accurate wording.

Possible opening: I left your interview coordination out of the summary, and I want to correct that accurately.

Success checks

- Name the omitted contribution without exaggerating it.
- Agree a concrete correction at the next meeting.
- Avoid demanding forgiveness or promising perfect future behavior.

Add a complication: The manager is tempted to promise that no contribution will ever be missed again.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Check meaning before assuming agreement

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Challenge ideas respectfully

Editing example: My concern is that the proposal assumes capacity we have not confirmed.

The revised sentence identifies a testable concern about the proposal. It leaves room for a constructive response.

Check 1: C - The proposal assumes the review is complete; the record shows it is still open.

A: This expresses a preference, but does not identify the assumption or the record that contradicts it.

B: This requests discussion without stating the specific assumption or evidence.

C: It connects the concern to a specific assumption and record.

Check 2: B - Could we resolve the missing approval before confirming the plan?

A: General feedback does not directly address the missing approval.

B: It names the unresolved condition and a practical next step.

C: This confirms the plan before resolving the stated approval condition.

Model response: I'd like to understand the objection. Which assumption do you disagree with? Please focus on the proposal so we can examine it together.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Make authority and participation clear

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: B - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

B: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

C: Silence does not establish agreement.

Check 2: A - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

B: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

C: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

Model response: I'll make the final decision on staffing. Before that, I want each of you to suggest one option. You can speak now or send a note after the meeting.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Negotiate realistic commitments

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

C: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: We can send an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday. Which would meet your need? If we send the estimate, I'll label the figures as provisional.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Include every voice in a meeting

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: Silence does not establish agreement.

B: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

C: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

Check 2: B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

B: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

C: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

Model response: Let's hear Morgan's question first. Then we'll take one comment at a time. Before we finish, can we confirm who approves the plan and when?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Give specific, useful feedback

Editing example: The last two reports omitted the agreed summary section.

The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Check 1: B - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.

A: Commitment is an interpretation, not a description of what the updates contained.

B: The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.

C: "Less professional" is an evaluation; it does not identify a specific observable omission.

Check 2: A - What is making this part of the task difficult?

A: An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

B: A promise does not reveal the obstacle or what support would help.

C: This proposes a solution before finding out what is making the task difficult.

Model response: The last two reports arrived on Tuesday instead of Monday. That delayed our review. What is getting in the way, and what support would help you meet Monday's deadline?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Coordinate across offices

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

B: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

C: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

Check 2: C - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

B: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

C: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

Model response: Headquarters needs early notice of delays; the branch needs time to deliver the work. Could we try a short daily exception report and review the arrangement in two weeks?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

B: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

C: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

Check 2: B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

B: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

C: The reader still lacks the information they need.

Model response: I interrupted you and missed part of your concern. I'm sorry. Could we return to it now? At our next meeting, I'll let you finish before I respond.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Professional audience: managers, cross-border teams, HR partners, and meeting facilitators

Scope: Ask about individual preferences and team norms. Nationality, accent, silence, or directness does not tell you what a person believes or how they will behave.

Lesson 01: Check meaning before assuming agreement

Original fictional case: In a branch meeting, two colleagues say the launch plan is "fine." One later emails a concern about staffing. The manager had recorded agreement.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: assumption: Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification. / clarification: A question or explanation that makes meaning more precise. / expectation: A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: When you said the plan was fine, did you mean you supported the date or still had concerns? Let's check each person's view before I record a decision.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level